

Between World and Narrative: Fictional Epigraphs and Critical World-Building

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GNOMIC UTTERANCES. These are traditional, and are set at the head of each section of the Guidebook. The reason for them is lost in the mists of HISTORY. They are culled by the Management from a mighty collection of wise sayings probably compiled by a SAGE—probably called Ka’a Orto’o—some centuries before the Tour begins. The Rule is that no Utterance has anything whatsoever to do with the section it precedes. Nor, of course, has it anything to do with GNOMES.

— Diana Wynne Jones, *The Tough Guide to Fantasyland*

IN HER SATIRE ON QUEST FANTASY, *THE TOUGH GUIDE TO FANTASYLAND*, Diana Wynne Jones addresses the topic of world-intrinsic epigraphs (80). Such epigraphs, she suggests, are vague and cryptic texts with no relevance to the story that they accompany. However, the *Tough Guide*’s own “gnomic utterances” are connected to the section they precede by beginning with the letter of their section, and each constitutes a tiny story. Through their various viewpoints, voices, and themes, Jones’s epigraphs form a small fantasy world that provides a foil to the parodic world constructed in the book’s introduction and main entries. For the attentive reader, the *Tough Guide* demonstrates the world-building power of epigraphs. In this article, we will establish the importance of world-intrinsic epigraphs in analyzing a secondary fantasy world by showing how they work through four key functions.

The more different a fictional world is from the actual world in which we (authors, readers, critics) live, the greater the effort required to bring the world to life—to build it. The term “world-building” has come to take on a variety of meanings depending on what activity the user is interested in. In creative-writing workshops, computer-game construction, and role-playing game discussions, it is often equated with the creative work of producers (authors, video-game writers, game masters). Literary critics and philosophers concern themselves with the cognitive re-creation of consumers (readers,

players, audiences). But in order to critically analyze a fictional world, whether it is presented in a text, a film, a game, or any other medium or combination of media, scholars also need to assemble the world from its various elements. We have previously referred to this activity as “critical world-building” and have demonstrated how it can provide the basis for fruitful scholarly interpretation (Ekman, “Entering”; “Map”; “Vitruvius”; Ekman and Taylor; Taylor, *Patricia A. McKillip*; Taylor and Ekman).

In this article, we employ a critical world-building perspective to address an element of world-building that has been given very little attention in previous scholarship. While the functions of epigraphs have been discussed by previous scholars (most notably Gérard Genette), epigraphs in fantasy and genre literature generally have been much neglected. This is particularly true for scholarship on the function of fictional epigraphs that are presented as part of secondary worlds. Our aim is to specifically analyze the functions of secondary-world epigraphs as world-building elements by examining their paratextual and intertextual characteristics.

We will begin by briefly discussing critical world-building and epigraphs, before more closely examining the epigraph’s multiple functions as elements of critical world-building. We focus our examinations on four overarching functions. The first two functions concern how the epigraphs contribute information about the world in approximately the same way that the main text does, although the epigraph contributions gain relative prominence through the epigraph’s position at the edge of the work. One function, which we believe is all but unavoidable for all epigraphs, has to do with how epigraphs impact the world’s mood and set expectations for the development of that world in the main text. The other function is also ubiquitous and pertains to how epigraphs provide, and highlight, various details in the world. The other two functions we address concern epigraphs that give rise to effects in their relation between epigraph and main text. Of these two functions, one deals with how epigraphs provide multiple perspectives of the fictional world and the other addresses the many ways in which the fictional epigraph takes on a double nature with regard to itself, the fictional world, and the main text. The overall movement in presenting the functions of epigraphs is thus from atmosphere to description and then from perspective to ontology.

By analyzing these four functions, we demonstrate how fictional epigraphs are not only relevant in interpreting secondary worlds but can be key in understanding the world’s composition. The themes and world elements foregrounded by an epigraph’s mood and details bring out dominant or central aspects of the world’s universe, a universe that can transform into a “polyverse” through the alternative voices and perspectives introduced from the edge of the main text. That edge, in turn, becomes blurred and indistinct

when the text, in the guise of a world-intrinsic epigraph, masquerades as its own intertext. These transformative functions are valuable in analyzing world-intrinsic epigraphs and secondary worlds, but we submit that they can also be useful when looking at other kinds of epigraphs in other types of worlds. The functions might not be as common nor as world-defining as in the cases we examine in this article, but we have added some comments regarding possible broader applications of our findings for each function.

Fictional Worlds and Critical World-building

Fictional worlds are artistic creations that are, in a sense, treated as having an existence beyond the medium through which they are created. “World” is used here to refer not only to a (fictional) physical space; in keeping with, for example, Marie-Laure Ryan and Mark J. P. Wolf, we consider a fictional world to consist of its physical space along with everything contained in this space, such as flora and fauna, weather and history, and peoples and their cultures. Ryan observes that for fictional worlds

the text is apprehended as a window on something that exists outside of language and extends in time and space well beyond the window frame. To speak of a textual world means to draw a distinction between a realm of language, made of names, definite descriptions, sentences, and propositions, and an extralinguistic realm of characters, objects, facts, and states of affairs serving as referents to the linguistic expressions. (91)

According to Ryan, fictional worlds are treated as if they are described (referentially) in a medium rather than created by the use of that medium. The distinction between the “realm of language” and the perceived “extralinguistic realm” that linguistic expressions simultaneously bring into being and refer to is even more pronounced in so-called secondary worlds (Tolkien 132; Zahorski and Boyer 59-61). The term “secondary world” has a long history in fantasy theory, dating back to J.R.R. Tolkien’s expressing world-building in terms of “sub-creation”: the author creates a “Secondary World” (as opposed to the “Primary World” of the author and reader) into which the reader’s mind can enter and according to whose laws the story is “true” (132). The binary division between primary and secondary worlds has been called into question, with some critics arguing that there is a spectrum of fictional worlds, from close copies of the actual one to fully secondary worlds (Wolf 26; Piatti 137, 141). This article focuses primarily on fictional worlds that are largely secondary and demonstrates how a particular paratextual element can contribute to the critical construction and analysis of a fully realized secondary world.

World-building can be approached from several directions or discussed as different, if overlapping, types of processes. The creative processes of

an author writing a world differ from the cognitive processes of a reader re-creating it, and both of these are, arguably, different from the fan's detailed compilation of information. Our main interest is the critical methods that a scholar uses in constructing a world out of a work of fiction in order to analyze and interpret it. Such "critical world-building" keeps the text in focus, rather than the methods through which the author imagines a world or the processes through which a reader reimagines it (Ekman and Taylor 10-11). In critical world-building, the fictional world is constructed as a composite, by relating the mainly sequential presentation of the world in text and images to a more holistic perspective. The world is also placed in a critical context of genre conventions and theoretical discourses (Ekman and Taylor 11-12). The building blocks—"elements"—of such a composite, critical world have a dynamic rather than a static relationship to each other (Ekman, "Vitruvius" 119). Combining one detail with another in the analysis, (re-) interpreting something in light of a new genre trope, or adopting a different theoretical perspective could cause a chain of new realizations of how the world functions in relation to its narrative(s). In this article the term "world-building" is thus understood as "critical world-building."

Epigraphs

In his work on paratexts (material that exists on, or constitute, the threshold between a text and the not-text that surrounds it), Genette defines the epigraph

roughly as a quotation placed *en exergue* [in the exergue], generally at the head of a work or a section of a work; literally, *en exergue* means *off* the work, which is going a little too far. Here the exergue is, rather, at the *edge* of the work, generally closest to the text—thus, following the dedication, if there is one. (144)

Genette's definition does not specify what kind of quotation constitutes an epigraph, only where it can (generally) be found in the physical structure of the work. As quotations, epigraphs consist of a quoted text and an attribution of that text, which in this article will be referred to as the epigraph's "text" and its "source." Epigraphs, according to Genette, are paratexts, types of texts that establish the boundary between the world of the text and the world outside it. His focus is largely on the relation between the epigraph and the narrative, although the first two functions of epigraphs that he mentions involve comments on title and text (156-57) rather than on story or narrative. Instead of focusing on narrative, this article focuses on the functions that epigraphs have in relation to the worlds of the text and more specifically on secondary worlds and epigraphs intrinsic to these worlds. We leave to others to explore

how fictional epigraphs relate to narrative and story and how they function in genre literature more broadly.

Not all works set in secondary worlds use world-intrinsic epigraphs, however. Some include quotations from actual-world sources, often as epigraphs to the entire work or to longer sections. They function more in line with how Genette discusses epigraphs. We do not focus on these kinds of epigraphs, but as demonstration, a few examples are addressed briefly. Philip Pullman's *Northern Lights* (1995; US title *The Golden Compass*) opens with a stanza from John Milton's *Paradise Lost* (1667), Steph Swainston's *The Year of Our War* (2004) with a line from T. S. Eliot's "Gerontion" (1920), and Sylvia Kelso's *Amberlight* (2007) with quotations from both William Shakespeare's *Anthony and Cleopatra* (1623) and Tolkien's *The Lord of the Rings* (1954–55). Pullman and Swainston place their epigraphs before the main text, while Kelso introduces each of her two parts with an epigraph. These epigraphs provide a thematic commentary on the text they precede (and, in the case of *Northern Lights*, establish Milton's text as a foil to the novel), a function that Genette refers to as canonical (157). More obliquely, each epigraph is also "a signal [...] of culture, a password of intellectuality. [...] With it, [the author] chooses his peers and thus his place in the pantheon" (Genette 160). The references to canonical works at the beginning of genre novels thus encourages the reader to take the texts and their authors seriously, while emphasizing the difference between the actual world of the sources and the secondary worlds of the stories. Kelso in particular uses her epigraphs to blur the border between canonical and non-canonical by equating Shakespeare and Tolkien and by implying that both authors have relevance for her own text.

Functions of World-intrinsic Epigraphs

In Genette's definition cited above, it should be noted that he only considers the epigraph to be "roughly" a quotation. In fact, he acknowledges that the "quotation" could be what he calls "autographic," made up by the author (145). In a text set in a secondary world the autographic epigraph is usually attributed to a source within that world rather than to a source in the actual world. Such world-intrinsic references can potentially contribute to the world either by extending it through new information or by offering alternative perspectives on world elements that are established in the main text. At the very least, the epigraphs establish a particular mood or atmosphere, or can guide reader expectations.

Function One: Setting the Mood

Regardless of whatever else an epigraph contributes to the secondary world, it helps set the mood. That paratexts can affect reader expectations has been pointed out by other critics. Genette discusses how they can be "puzzling" for

the reader and “more affective than intellectual” (158); according to Mike Cadden, epigraphs can “communicate thematic expectations” (137); and Joseph Besa suggests that literary elements have a “presence,” that is, they directly influence the reader’s sensibilities (323). Such influence, Besa claims, includes the way in which titles can either confuse or control the expectations of the reader (325). We argue that other paratexts, such as epigraphs, can have the same effect, which we summarize under the term “mood” for simplicity.

The challenge that the mood poses in critical world-building lies in its intangibility. All epigraphs set some mood, like a first chord before an orchestra launches into a symphony. Through its position at the front of the text, this mood can accentuate, clarify, or boost a particular theme or aspect of the world. Like any world element, the mood of the epigraph should be read in relation to the world as a whole, and the mood conveyed by the entire text.

A well-known example of an epigraph that sets the mood for the world is the verse that precedes the text in Ursula Le Guin’s *A Wizard of Earthsea* (1968): “Only in silence the word, / only in dark the light, / only in dying life: / bright the hawk’s flight / on the empty sky” (6). The verse is given the source “*The Creation of Éa*.” Not much detail about the secondary world is provided, apart from the name “Éa,” which is not specified but could, for instance, be interpreted to be the name of the world. It is confirmed that the world contains hawks; the other concepts are so common that their absence from a world would have been more noteworthy than their presence is. With its four yin-and-yang-like images contrasting nothingness and presence, its repetition of “only” suggesting simultaneously exhortation and acceptance, and its contrast between three abstract nouns and the final concrete image of a hawk in flight, the verse suggests a philosophical context similar to Daoism. There is a sense of balance and duality as well as movement. The source title suggests a creation myth or other story central to the secondary world’s culture, and the Daoist-like worldview communicated by the verse can be taken to have a prominent position in the world. The main text confirms that *The Creation of Éa* is “the oldest of all songs” (Le Guin, *Wizard* 33), and the epigraph’s contemplative mood and sense of balance parallels the wise master wizards in the book, whose magic can overturn the balance of the world and who therefore strive to maintain that balance. The mood established by the epigraph permeates the world, reinforcing the focus on balance.

Le Guin’s epigraph can be used to demonstrate how the mood of the epigraph is connected to the mood of the world as a whole. Our contention is that although there is nothing in *The Creation of Éa* text that does not exist in almost every secondary world, the mood it communicates nevertheless makes it difficult to conceive of it as an epigraph to a great many other fantasy worlds. For all that Tolkien’s world is called Eä (a fairly close match), for instance, the sense of balance and acceptance in the epigraph would be a bad

fit for his world as presented in *The Lord of the Rings* or *The Silmarillion* (1977). In Tolkien's world, strife and oppositions dominate, and themes of light in darkness and life in death, although present, are not as prominent. Adding the Earthsea epigraph would shift the thematic focus of Tolkien's world.

Some epigraphs are so brief and general in nature that their presence likely contributes nothing but a vague mood regarding the world. In Steven Brust's *Jherig* (1983), each chapter is introduced by a short aphorism, maxim, or motto, and most of them only add to the general atmosphere of the world (although they are usually notionally connected to the events of the chapter). They comprise a wide range of styles, from formal, old-fashioned, and poetic to modern and colloquial. Examples include "There is no substitute for good manners—except fast reflexes" (29), "One man's mistake is another man's opportunity" (117), and "Tread lightly near thine own traps" (143). Especially when considered together, they produce a mood suitable to a world of larceny, assassination, and general skullduggery. The epigraphs convey a sense of what Lisbeth Klastrup and Susana Tosca call a world's *ethos*, "the explicit and implicit ethics of the world and (moral) codex of behaviour" (412). (Klastrup and Tosca discuss transmedial worlds, but we suggest that their concepts can be applied to monomedial worlds as well.) A world's *ethos* is a core element for analyzing the moral and ethical dimensions of a world and its inhabitants, and the mood of the epigraphs can offer a basis for identifying that *ethos*.

Apart from the *ethos* they communicate, Brust's epigraphs are slightly humorous in tone. A comedic mood is another function of some epigraphs, as observed by for instance Margarete Rubik (170) with regards to Jasper Fforde's *The Eyre Affaire* (2001; explored in more depth below). Humorous epigraphs (apart from invoking a mirthful mood in a reader) can be used to draw attention to genre tropes or social conventions through satire or parody (Jones, in her Gnostic Utterances entry in *The Tough Guide to Fantasyland*, exemplifies this). In this way, an epigraph can indicate that, and possibly which, particular intertexts should be brought into the critical construction of the world. At the very least, a comedic mood signals that the world does not necessarily conform to, for example, traditional logic, psychological realism, or genre conventions. Even the world's internal consistency, that central tenet of the fantasy world (Irwin 27; Ekman, *Here* 5-6), might be sacrificed at the altar of levity.

To some extent, this function applies to all epigraphs in all genres of fiction. Genette observes how an epigraph has a "sense of indirect backing that its presence at the edge of a text gives rise to" (159). That sense of indirect backing amplifies the mood of the epigraph and provides that opening chord that accentuates the dominant themes. This chord might not always be as loud or as clear as the fictive epigraph, which harmonizes by virtue of being designed specifically for a particular world, but it is still present.

The epigraph's mood is a vital, underlying part of a world and by failing to take it into account, one risks failing to see the entirety of the world. The mood established by the epigraph, either by complementing or contrasting the mood foregrounded by the main text, can draw attention to those minor themes that are eclipsed by the dominant themes. At the very least, epigraphs indicate a mood that can function as an interpretive lens through which the world can be analyzed.

Function Two: Adding Details

Arguably, all epigraphs contribute to setting the mood of a secondary world in some way, but many if not most epigraphs also add more specific details to the world. Details can be added through the epigraph text, through the source given for that text, or through the combination of source and text. Regardless of what particular topic the epigraph addresses, or to what extent it deals with that topic, details about the world can be gleaned from studying it.

A fictional world is made up from the totality of the explicit details given in the text, along with their implications. As we outlined above, in critical world-building details are analyzed in relation to each other, to the totality of the world, and to a generic and critical context (for a practical example, see Taylor and Ekman). The details that an epigraph affords to the world come with that “sense of indirect backing” that, Genette observes, an epigraph acquires from its liminal position (159); epigraphs may not be pivotal to a particular interpretation, but they should not be blithely ignored. Like the mood, they indicate a possible focus or emphasis to the world-building.

Epigraphs can contribute marginally or substantially to the world depending on the extent of the epigraph and its source. Such contributions can be of a general nature, such as the existence of a type of creature, form of government, or religious practice, or provide fairly specific information, for instance the name of a city, the history of a given person, or a description of a geographic feature. For example, the chapter epigraph “The bite of the yendi can never be fully healed” (Brust 159) includes the fact that in this world there is a creature called “yendi” and adds information about its bite. On its own, this piece of information may appear inconsequential, but reading it in relation to the broader context of the novel and its world tells us more about the creature as a cultural entity. The yendi is mentioned only a handful of times in *Jheræg*, twice in epigraphs. The first is a poem listing noble Houses that are named after various creatures, in which the yendi “coils and strikes, unseen” (17). The second epigraph, cited above, is a saying like all chapter epigraphs in *Jheræg*. In the main text the yendi is referred to once in an idiom (55) and once in a metaphor (114). The web of relations between details and implications bring out the cultural meaning of the creature (its importance is confirmed by the next novel in the series, *Yendi* [1984]).

Close readings of an epigraph can uncover a great deal even before its details are introduced into and related to the entirety of the world. The text preceding Sean Russell's *The One Kingdom* (2001), "To my children I bequeath my hatred of the Renné, for all the atrocities they have committed against us, and all that they will commit," in combination with its source, "The final testament of Abril Wills," offers some specifics about the feud that exists between the Renné and Wills families. Even more detail about the world is provided by an epigraph such as:

Here we find further argument for Gotagga's supposition that the world is round. How else could all men stand higher than their brothers?

— Ajencis, *Discourse on War* (Bakker 54)

Two people are mentioned by name along with a work written by the second person. But the text is also clearly a part of a wider philosophical discussion that combines the geographical theories of Gotagga with Ajencis's discourse on a different subject. The state of science and learning in R. Scott Bakker's world is, partially, revealed through the epigraph. The spherical nature of the world has neither been proven nor disproven but it is a subject for discussion. Through linguistic markers such as "further argument," "supposition," and "discourse," the writing suggests a philosophical treatise and thus hints at a form of society in which such treatises are written. And through the stress on "men" and "brothers" a patriarchal society, or at least a society in which war is a male concern, is implied. In both cases the details and their implications foreground central characteristics and themes of the world.

The linguistic form of an epigraph can in itself provide details about the secondary world. The meter and rhyme scheme of a song or poem and the style and stylistic devices used in a text add to the world. The epigraph called "Caspro's Hymn" that precedes the text in Le Guin's *Voices* (2006) is metered and has distinct stylistic traits, including a final rhyme (thee/liberty):

As in the dark of winter night
 Our eyes seek dawn,
 As in the bonds of bitter cold
 The heart craves sun,
 So blinded and so bound, the soul
 Cries out to thee:
 Be our light, our fire, our life,
 Liberty!

Apart from identifying a person, Caspro (a character in the book), the negative connotations of cold and darkness and the positive connotations of light, sun,

and fire provide information about the cultural and physical setting. The word “hymn” implies a religious context, but it is unclear whether the hymn invokes a deity or just the concept of liberty—or both. The epigraph thus adds to the religious and temporal conflict between colonizers and colonized that is central to both world and narrative in the novel.

The epigraph source, as well as the epigraph itself, can provide information that indicates a way to approach a secondary world. Naming customs, titles, and social positions, and what text genres exist in the world can be determined from the sources given. Bakker’s *Ajencis* and the *Discourse on War* have been discussed already, and Bakker further includes a wide range of fictional persons and text genres in his epigraphs, from religious and philosophical treatises to proverbs and anonymous letters. Some of the writers are characters named in the story, but many more are not. Instead, they populate the secondary world with people who extend the social world beyond the story by providing access to a larger intellectual tradition and cultural history. In *Gate of Ivrel* (1976), C. J. Cherryh expands the world of what appears to be a fantasy novel with three epigraphs cast as a prologue, with the sources “Journal, Union Science Bureau, Vol. XXX, p. 22,” “Book of Embry, Hait-an-Koris,” and “Annals of Baïen-an.” The first source indicates a scientific journal with page numbers, carefully cited in a way appropriate for scientific discourse, and adds the idea of some sort of modern political unit (a union) with organized bureaucracy. It is a source that as a fictional epigraph would have suggested science fiction rather than fantasy, were it not for the sharp contrast with the sense of story and history that the other two sources communicate through “book of” and “annals of.” Even without reading the texts of the epigraphs, it is possible to determine that the secondary world contains a conflict between science and tradition, suggesting that mix of genres sometimes referred to as “science fantasy.” Regardless of how the text portrays the world, the epigraph points out the generic context in which the world should be constructed for analysis.

This function is particularly consequential when the world in question is a secondary world. For non-genre fiction set in a version of the actual world, an epigraph from *The Lord of the Rings* does not mean that there are orcs, hobbits, or magical rings in the world. However, the epigraph can still accentuate particular details of the world or offer analytical routes into the text.

The details afforded by an epigraph are part of the entirety of the world, and as such cannot simply be left out of the world-building endeavor. On the contrary, their position at the edge of the text suggests that they deserve critical attention, although not every detail or implication is relevant to every interpretation of the world.

Function Three: Adding Perspectives

Epigraphs can reveal background facts that explain and familiarize a strange world. Fforde extends the secondary world beyond what is created through the first-person narrative by using chapter epigraphs that reflect a wide range of text genres, from biographies and press interviews to parliamentary speeches and scholarly works. The many sources add to the appearance of completeness of the world, particularly as they all seem to be authoritative nonfiction sources. In other words, the epigraphs introduce a make-believe reference world for the novels (Rubik 170).

The numerous sources of the Fforde epigraphs not only provide solidity to the world, they offer several different voices through which the world is described, a multitude of perspectives similar to what Mikhail Bakhtin calls “polyphony” (6). Even the antagonist of *The Eyre Affaire* is afforded his own epigraphs, though the main narrative is largely told from the viewpoint of the protagonist. In his discussion of Fyodor Dostoevsky’s works, Bakhtin argues that Dostoevsky’s characters are given their own independent voices with which they describe their world.

[T]he utterly incompatible elements comprising Dostoevsky’s material are distributed among several worlds and several autonomous consciousnesses; they are presented not within a single field of vision but within several fields of vision, each full and of equal worth; and it is not the material directly but these worlds [...] that combine in a higher unity, a unity, so to speak, of the second order, the unity of the polyphonic novel. (16)

Epigraphs with different sources and voices similarly provide several fields of vision although these fields of visions are generally not “full and of equal worth”: usually the world of the main novel text offers the fuller, more “worthy” vision of the world, made more complex by the perspectives promoted by the epigraphs. That paratexts can create counter-narratives has already been suggested (McCormack 38-39), and as demonstrated by Jones’s epigraphs, paratexts such as epigraphs can even offer “counter-worlds” that destabilize the world constructed in the main text. The variety of sources as well as content of the Fforde epigraphs means that quite different aspects of the text are highlighted. In chapter 8, the epigraph reads:

“... There is no point in expending good money on the pursuit of an engine that can power aircraft without propellers. What is wrong with airships anyway? They have borne mankind aloft for over a hundred relatively accident-free years and I see no reason to impugn their popularity ...”

Congresswoman Kelly, arguing against parliamentary funds for the development of a new form of propulsion, August 1972. (Fforde 77)

This epigraph, predating the main narrative by thirteen years, provides information about the air-travel technology of the fictional world and establishes an alternative perspective on air travel. While the main text describes travel by airship as peaceful, idyllic, and completely accepted by the narrator, the epigraph gives an impression of airship travel as being contested. Congresswoman Kelly's voice defends the traditional way of flying against possible new technologies, implying that airships are under threat. Her success becomes clear from the narrator's description: more than a decade later, airships are the standard means for long-distance travel, their popularity clearly not impugned. Through the epigraph, the "contemporary but counterfactual Britain" (Mikkonen 117) of the novel gains a dynamism that the main narrative alone does not provide. Airships as the primary form of air travel is not the unchanging and unquestioned situation that the narrative implies; it is a situation that has been challenged and defended. Other epigraphs add other perspectives to the world, for example suggesting that the exact nature of time is irrelevant (Fforde 11), extolling "true and baseless evil" (31), and implying that Britain has characteristics of an autocratic police state (107). Ultimately, these perspectives combine into that "higher unity [...] of the second order" that Bakhtin mentions, creating what could be called a textual "polyverse" rather than a "universe."

In *Deadhouse Gates* (2000), Steven Erikson produces just such a fictional polyverse by supplying epigraphs from a variety of sources. One third of the chapters are preceded by epigraphs referring to works of an informative or factual nature, often histories, and another third describe events or places in verse form. A typical example is the excerpt from Ilem Trauth's *Lives of the Conquered* preceding chapter 3:

The Red Blades were, at this time, pre-eminent among those pro-Malazan organizations that arose in occupied territories. Viewing themselves as progressive in their embrace of the values of imperial unification, this quasi-military cult became infamous with their brutal pragmatism when dealing with dissenting kin...(86)

The voice of Ilem Trauth maintains a distance to its subject, placing the violent and fanatical group in a historical and political context. At the same time, it emphasizes history's judgment of the group as a "quasi-military cult [...] infamous [for] brutal pragmatism," as well as how they viewed themselves. Erikson's epigraphs in *Deadhouse Gates* present a variety of perspectives, based both on the identity of the source and the genre of the epigraph text. Distanced historical or factual prose accounts are mixed with more emotive verse descriptions, and the sources include unfamiliar people as well as characters who appear in the text. Some sources occur more than

once, emphasizing their perspectives even when these are voiced only through the epigraphs.

Epigraphs can determine the reliability of the main text (or its narrator) by either implying that the epigraph is the less reliable retelling (a ballad, prophesy, or tale for instance) and the main text is a more reliable version of events; or vice versa,¹ in which the epigraph is a more objective account (for instance a scholarly or even scientific text) and the main text is more biased. An example that conspicuously constructs this kind of multiple perspectives through its epigraphs is Patricia A. McKillip's *The Bards of Bone Plain* (2010). This is not the first instance of McKillip questioning the nature and shaping of story, poetry, and song (Taylor, *Time* 116-21) but it is the only time in which she uses epigraphs to do so. Every second chapter in the book begins with an extract from something that reads like a research paper (revealed near the end of the main text to be written by one of the characters). This section is followed by additional epigraphs, snippets from what are presumably its world-intrinsic "source material," before the rest of the chapter continues to narrate the events.² In the second chapter, for example, the epigraph reads:

Across a thousand years of poetry, we have come to know Nairn the Wanderer, the Fool, the Cursed, the Unforgiven intimately through hundreds of poems, ballads, tales... But of the man behind, within the music and the poetry, who cast his unending shadow across a millennium and more, we know astonishingly little. (14)

The style is that of a scholarly treatise that emerges from within the fictional world, introducing Nairn and his various epithets, outlining the sources through which he is known, and establishing (like so many scholarly papers of the actual world) that the subject, Nairn, is important but that there is a lack of knowledge about him. The text sets itself up as an authoritative source while at the same time suggesting that the poems, ballads, and tales by or about Nairn do not convey a true picture. There are details about Nairn, indicating his fame (he has been represented in multiple ways and thus has multiple epithets) and, through the negative connotations of the epithets, that he has not led an easy life: "the Fool," "the Cursed," "the Unforgiven." The references to Nairn's immortality seem to place the epigraphic text within the secondary world; immortality comes across as a matter of fact rather than poetic conceits. The epigraph's scholarly perspective thus offers a perspective of the world of *Bone Plain* that complements that of the main text.

The extract from the research paper is followed by a second epigraph with a different style and perspective, which adds to the polyverse of *Bone Plain*. It seems to be a part of the paper's "source material," a snippet from a ballad, similarly from within the world.

Dark his hair, darker his eye,
 Sweet as cream and honey his voice,
 O the charm in it, O the lure of it,
 He could wile a smile from the moon.

Fragment of "Ballad of the Pig-Singer," Anonymous (McKillip 15)

Through its two contrasting perspectives, this epigraph is given a double function. The text is from a ballad, with stylistic features (short lines, repetitions, parallelisms, strong imagery) to support that, as well as having the function as scholarly source material (presumably for the paper it follows) through the epigraph's source. The juxtaposition of the two epigraphs imply that Nairn and the Pig-Singer of the ballad are the same person, but the descriptions offered of him in the latter are more focused on positive traits than are the epithets in the paper extract. The portrayal is more romantic, appropriately for a ballad, with emphasis on the Pig-Singer's ability to enchant. The contrast between, on the one hand, the title's reference to the prosaic pig and the less than romantic job of singing to them, and, on the other, the melodious, positive attributes of the epigraph text mirrors the contrast between the different perspectives of the two epigraphs.

McKillip's epigraphs are in dialogue with each other, as well as with the narrative as a whole, a conversation that builds a more complex world than a single voice would. According to Graham Allen, "[a]ll utterances depend on or call to other utterances; no utterance itself is singular; all utterances are shot through with other, competing and conflicting voices" (27). Allen makes a point regarding intertextuality, but it is also illuminating in the context of McKillip's epigraphs. The epigraphs in her novel offer a particularly striking example of "competing and conflicting voices." The various types of "source material" produce a multifaceted portrayal of Nairn by themselves, a portrayal that is analyzed and examined in the scholarly extracts. The dual perspective of cultural artefacts and scholarly analysis is then combined with the rest of the main text, creating complementary as well as sometimes conflicting worldviews.

A dual or multiple perspective can be constructed even with regular epigraphs in a non-fantasy work. Epigraphs from actual newspapers can be used for a fictional account of a historical event; a story about another writer's minor character can be provided with epigraphs from the original writer's texts (e.g. a story focalizing Irene Adler using quotes from the original Sherlock Holmes stories); or a police procedural can offer a dual perspective through epigraphs from police investigation manuals. If fictional epigraphs are used, alternative perspectives can be established in the same way as for secondary worlds.

The various alternative perspectives carried by McKillip's, Fforde's, and Erikson's epigraphs do not arise solely from world-intrinsic interrelations.

Complementary and competing ways of seeing the world emerge from references to the fictional world as well as to text genres and situations of the actual world in which different views can be proposed or argued. The epigraphs are parts of the work of fiction while mimicking text genres that are not fiction, such as the research paper, the parliamentary debate, the historical treatise. Their many voices can thus rely on both polyphony and mimicry to build a more complex world.

Function Four: Double Nature

The combination of secondary worlds and world-intrinsic epigraphs means that the epigraphs lose the paratextual characteristic of constituting a threshold, while remaining in the exergue position that Genette uses to define them. They acquire a double nature that in itself contributes to world-building: the secondary world leaks into the paratext, establishing itself as part of the outside perspective on the text and thus lending strength to the proposition that the secondary world exists as more than an aesthetic artefact. Using world-intrinsic paratexts is a well-established way to connect the fantastic to the actual world. Examples include Tolkien's prefatory "On Hobbits" in *The Lord of the Rings* and Jonathan Swift's maps in *Gulliver's Travels* (1726), on which the imaginary lands are located near or in actual geographic places.

World-intrinsic fictional epigraphs are constructed to give the impression of being paratextual and intertextual while in fact being part of the text. They are internal references to the text-world rather than external references to other texts, other worlds. Genette argues that "[autographic] epigraphs that are (almost) openly accepted by authors as their own belong [...] to authorial discourse, and for this reason [he] would readily say that their function is that of a succinct preface" (153). He cites Walter Scott's introduction to *Chronicles of Canongate* (1827), in which Scott claims that he "drew on [his] memory as long as [he] could, and, when that failed, eked it out with invention" (qtd. in Genette 147). In secondary-world fantasy such change of function is less straightforward. Fantasy fiction is founded on the tacit agreement between writer and reader that although the contents of the book are not "real" or "possible," they will be treated as if they were (Ekman, *Here* 5; Irwin 9). By this generic agreement the epigraphs are (or should be) accepted to be autographic while at the same time being treated as if they were not.

This doubleness in fictional epigraphs, where they are known to be fictional but read as factual, blurs the boundary between the actual and fictional worlds. McKillip provides a clear example of this. Formally and stylistically, the epigraphs signal particular text types, such as research paper and ballad, and must be read in terms of these. In particular the former text type encourages a reading as if it were factual, a scholarly text based on a substantial source material, with claims to "objectivity" and "truth," whereas the main narrative

is “only” a story. On the other hand, the narrative focus of the main text gives it more authority than do its epigraphs, and the paper extracts of the epigraphs are in fact written by a character in the main narrative. The boundary between epigraph and main text thus becomes blurred.

This blurring happens not only between epigraph and main text but between the actual and the fictional. Epigraphs that cite actual, nonfiction sources can be used to extend the fictional world outwards into the actual (Thomas 305), and fictional epigraphs can create a similar extension of the fictional world. This effect can be explained by understanding world-intrinsic epigraphs in terms of “fraudulent artifacts,” that is

a text purporting to be a particular form of writing—a journal entry, a note, a yearbook letter, an e-mail, a transcript of a speech, a grocery list, a musical score, a screenplay—which also tells a story, stirs thought and emotion, inspires inquiry, initiates action, and/or calls into question that which is—or has purported to be—real. (Shields and Vollmer 13)

The use of fraudulent artifacts in fantastic fiction in the sense of one text type taking the form of another is neither uncommon nor limited to text types easily shaped into stories, as illustrated by examples such as Garth Nix’s “Read It in the Headlines!” (2005), Lisa Goldstein’s “Reader’s Guide” (2008), and Kat Howard’s “Choose Your Own Adventure” (2011). Shields and Vollmer use the term for entire stories written according to the conventions of a non-narrative or nonfiction text type, but we would extend the usage to cover *parts* of a document as well, such as epigraphs. The fictional epigraph is doubly fraudulent. It is fiction that takes on the form of a particular kind of paratext, but it is also fraudulent in the sense that it purports to quote from some existing, world-intrinsic source, in effect bringing that source into existence by implication. Through this double “fraud,” epigraphs add dimensions to the world that can provide information on world elements, such as geography, history, culture, scholarship, or naming practices, but they also extend the experience of the world, contributing to what Farah Mendlesohn and Edward James refer to as the “depth” of the world, a feeling of there being more world around the corner, to use their image (44).

Where the sustained counter-world built by McKillip’s epigraphs derives its complexity from the contrasts between the epigraphs (the scholarly paper and the ballads, poems, and songs it analyzes) and the main text, other texts provide a multitude of fraudulent text types without providing any unifying perspective. Even more than in the case of Fforde, some of these other epigraphs adhere strictly to the conventions of factual text types. The extract from “*The Sha’ik Rebellion*,” by Cullaran, is deceptively similar to a scholarly text:

To this day it remains easy to ignore the fact that the Aren High Command was rife with treachery, rivalry and malice...The assertion that [the Aren High Command] was ignorant of the undercurrents in the countryside is, at best naïve, at worst cynical in the extreme... (Erikson 40; elisions and brackets in the original)

The voice of Cullaran is that of a historian looking back on events. It expresses an articulated political position, as evidenced by the negative “rife with treachery, rivalry and malice,” and the emphatic rhetorical figure used to describe the naïveté or cynicism of an assertion. Cullaran’s worldview is not that of the book’s omniscient and dispassionate narrator; it offers an alternative perspective on the world and the events in it. But the epigraph is “double-voiced” (Bakhtin 185); a second voice is present in it. Cullaran’s work has been quoted only in part. The two elisions and the clarification within square brackets imply the presence of both an *epigrapher* and an *epigraphed* (Genette 151). The perspective provided is not only Cullaran’s but that of an unidentified sender who, by selectively omitting parts of the text, has imposed their own worldview as well. The double voices and the conventions used to construct them help perpetrate the “fraud” by giving the impression both of a source from which the text is quoted and of a person who has done the quoting. Through these fraudulent references to an original source and to someone who has quoted from it, the epigraph extends Erikson’s world.

The multiple voices and multiple worlds, or polyphony and polyversality, that fictional, world-intrinsic epigraphs can give rise to undermine a totalizing critical world-building. Georg Stanitzek observes that paratexts can promote textual unity, but “they can only accomplish this without hindrance when they are not *read* in the strict sense of the word as such, that is, when no questions are asked about details” (34). The polyversality that critical world-building can give rise to has to take the world’s simultaneous unity and lack of unity into account when analyzing fictional epigraphs in relation to the fictional world.

The non-fictional epigraph is by definition a non-fraudulent paratext. But for all that Genette dismisses the “autographic” epigraph as a form of preface, it can achieve the same blurring between the actual and the fictional, not least if it takes on a fraudulent nonfiction guise. As such, an epigraph can give rise to a polyphonic polyverse regardless of genre and type of world. Imaginary intertexts and fictive facts can be evoked by an epigraph, supporting or undermining any fictive world.

Like the intertextual paratexts that they mimic, fictional epigraphs offer a choice of analytical path: to build the world of the main text or that of the intertext. Where actual epigraphs can create important, even crucial, intertextual resonances for a reader (Allen 105), fictional epigraphs can imitate such resonances. And while these resonances are only imitations on

one level, they also bring the resonating intertexts into (fictional) being by insisting on their existence. The critical world-building endeavor not only allows but encourages the (re)construction of fictional source-texts and an analysis of what those texts contribute to the world. The critic is invited to explore the epigraph source, but the intertext is absent, knowable only by chains of implications. In the readerly building of the world, the epigraph offers what Laurent Jenny regards as the alternative of all intertextual references, to either proceed in the text or to follow the intertext (113); in critical world-building, by its nature a holistic task (Ekman and Taylor 11-12), there is no saying which fork is of greater importance, along which path we can learn more about the world. Ultimately, any scholar who engages critically with world-building would be wise to take fictional epigraphs seriously.

Conclusion

Like many paratextual elements, the usefulness of world-intrinsic epigraphs to critical world-building is easily overlooked. Their contributions to the secondary world are often glossed over or ignored. When given due consideration, however, the ways in which they function with regard to world-building can have significant impact on the interpretation of the fictional world through a wealth of details and alternative perspectives, even introducing a counter-portrayal of the world. At the very least, the world-intrinsic epigraph sets a mood for the world that helps emphasize particular themes developed in the main text.

To analyze world-intrinsic epigraphs as paratexts requires an awareness of their fraudulent nature. They must be read both as texts from within the fictional world and as references to external sources. Through this doubleness, the details they contain extend the world. When the epigraphs are subjected to the combination of sequential, holistic, and layer analysis that is critical world-building, the fictional universe fractures into a polyverse. Several paths for understanding the world—and the work—appear, adding to its complexity and enabling a richer scholarly interpretation.

The four world-building functions that we have discussed for epigraphs do not necessarily cover all functions that epigraphs can have, but they are the ones that we observed over and over again in the world-intrinsic epigraphs of numerous secondary-world fantasy novels. Neither are these functions necessarily limited to epigraphs in secondary fantasy worlds, either; as we have pointed out, the four functions are conceivable for epigraphs in various forms of fiction. Furthermore, epigraphs can have other functions in other genres and other types of worlds. Our main assertion is ultimately that epigraphs are deserving of thoughtful analysis in any critical world-building enterprise. Whether they set a mood, foreground crucial or interesting details, offer alternative perspectives, add to the illusion that there is more world just out

of sight, or contribute to the world in other ways, the value of world-intrinsic epigraphs should not be underestimated.

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Matthew Oliver and Christine Mains helpfully pointed out how to proceed when we thought we had said all there was to say about moods, details, and broader applications. Helen Wedham provided valuable assistance with the mood function. We gratefully acknowledge the useful comments and suggestions from the *JFA* editors and the anonymous reviewers.

Notes

1. We have been unable to find examples of the latter, though it seems probable that they exist.
2. What “counts” as an epigraph? What length is too long (McKillip’s often run to one and a half pages), and what utterance is too small? Like the paratext more generally, epigraphs are formatted differently from the standard narrative to stand apart. Epigraphs (and paratexts in general) create a threshold between the text and what is beyond the text, not least by layout and formatting. It is beyond the scope of this article to explore this issue. We have decided arbitrarily that in McKillip’s case, the non-narrative texts are epigraphs, but in a book such as Jane Yolen’s *Sister Light, Sister Dark* (1988), the sections titled, for example, “The Myth” and “The Legend” are not epigraphs to the sections titled “The Story.” Someone else might have made a different choice and we would welcome further discussion on this.

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Abstract

Secondary worlds are constructed from a wide range of building blocks. In this article, epigraphs that refer to fictional sources in secondary worlds are analyzed in terms of their world-building characteristics. The analysis starts from the (implied) paratextual and intertextual properties of epigraphs that are part of and refer to a secondary world. Four functions of such world-intrinsic epigraphs are explored: the way in which they (1) set a mood that indicate the world's dominant themes or ethos; (2) give details that extend, explain, and familiarize the fictional world; and (3) provide perspectives with complementary or conflicting worldviews. Finally, (4) how the double nature of fictional epigraphs, as fictional paratexts and as purported quotations from world-intrinsic sources, extends and solidifies the world is addressed. These four functions lead us to conclude that fictional epigraphs deserve thoughtful analysis in any critical world-building endeavor.